Curious Standard

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FEATURES

The Four Desires Driving All Human Behavior: Bertrand Russell's Magnificent Nobel Prize Acceptance Speech

Maria Popova · The Marginalian (Brain Pickings)

"Nothing in the world is more exciting than a moment of sudden discovery or invention, and many more people are capable of experiencing such moments than is sometimes thought."

Bertrand Russell (May 18, 1872–February 2, 1970) endures as one of humanity's most lucid and luminous minds — an oracle of timeless wisdom on everything from what "the good life" really means to why "fruitful monotony" is essential for happiness to love, sex, and our moral superstitions . In 1950, he was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature for "his varied and significant writings in which he champions humanitarian ideals and freedom of thought." On December 11 of that year, 78-year-old Russell took the podium in Stockholm to receive the grand accolade.

Later included in Nobel Writers on Writing (public library) — which also gave us Pearl S. Buck, the youngest woman to receive the Nobel Prize in Literature, on art, writing, and the nature of creativity — his acceptance speech is one of the finest packets of human thought ever delivered from a stage.

Russell begins by considering the central motive driving human behavior:

All human activity is prompted by desire. There is a wholly fallacious theory advanced by some earnest moralists to the effect that it is possible to resist desire in the interests of duty and moral principle. I say this is fallacious, not because no man ever acts from a sense of duty, but because duty has no hold on him unless he desires to be dutiful. If you wish to know what men will do, you must know not only, or principally, their material circumstances, but rather the whole system of their desires with their relative strengths.

[...]

Man differs from other animals in one very important respect, and that is that he has some desires which are, so to speak, infinite, which can never be fully gratified, and which would keep him restless even in Paradise. The boa constrictor, when he has had an adequate meal, goes to sleep, and does not wake until he needs another meal. Human beings, for the most part, are not like this.

Russell points to four such infinite desires — acquisitiveness , rivalry , vanity , and love of power — and examines them in order:

Acquisitiveness — the wish to possess as much as possible of goods, or the title to goods — is a motive which, I suppose, has its origin in a combination of fear with the desire for necessaries. I once befriended two little girls from Estonia, who had narrowly escaped death from starvation in a famine. They lived in my family, and of course had plenty to eat. But they spent all their leisure visiting neighbouring farms and stealing potatoes, which they hoarded. Rockefeller, who in his infancy had experienced great poverty, spent his adult life in a similar manner.

[...]

However much you may acquire, you will always wish to acquire more; satiety is a dream which will always elude you.

In 1938, Henry Miller also articulated this fundamental driver in his brilliant meditation on how money became a human fixation . Decades later, modern psychologists would term this notion "the hedonic treadmill." But for Russell, this elemental driver is eclipsed by an even stronger one — our propensity for rivalry:

The world would be a happier place than it is if acquisitiveness were always stronger than rivalry. But in fact, a great many men will cheerfully face impoverishment if they can thereby secure complete ruin for their rivals. Hence the present level of taxation.

Rivalry, he argues, is in turn upstaged by human narcissism. In a sentiment doubly poignant in the context of today's social media, he observes:

Vanity is a motive of immense potency. Anyone who has much to do with children knows how they are constantly performing some antic, and saying "Look at me." "Look at me" is one of the most fundamental desires of the human heart. It can take innumerable forms, from buffoonery to the pursuit of posthumous fame.

[...]

It is scarcely possible to exaggerate the influence of vanity throughout the range of human life, from the child of three to the potentate at whose frown the world trembles.

But the most potent of the four impulses, Russell argues, is the love of power:

Love of power is closely akin to vanity, but it is not by any means the same thing. What vanity needs for its satisfaction is glory, and it is easy to have glory without power... Many people prefer glory to power, but on the whole these people have less effect upon the course of events than those who prefer power to glory... Power, like vanity, is insatiable. Nothing short of omnipotence could satisfy it completely. And as it is especially the vice of energetic men, the causal efficacy of love of power is out of all proportion to its frequency. It is, indeed, by far the strongest motive in the lives of important men.

[...]

Love of power is greatly increased by the experience of power, and this applies to petty power as well as to that of

(Edited for length)

How to Stop Doing and Start Living

Maria Popova · The Marginalian (Brain Pickings)

Nothing magnifies life — in the proper sense of the word, rooted in the Latin for "to make greater, to glorify" — more than the act of noticing its details, and nothing sanctifies it more: Kneeling to look at a lichen is a devotional act. We bless our own lives by recognizing and reverencing the details, the miniature marvels that make this improbable world what it is. And yet consciousness evolved to filter them out, to blur them into more abstract pictures we can parse, to sieves relevance from reality in order to save us from being too wonder-smitten by the flickering morning light on the edge of the kitchen sink and the iridescent eye of the house fly to move through our days. Cognitive scientists know this necessary ailment of consciousness: "Right now, you are missing the vast majority of what is happening around you," Alexandra Horowitz wrote in one of my favorite books , examining the "intentional, unapologetic discriminator" that is attention. Poets know the remedy: "Attention without feeling," Mary Oliver wrote , "is only a report."

Paying conscious attention, then, is our primary instrument of loving the world, abiding by Iris Murdoch's splendid definition of love as "the extremely difficult realisation that something other than oneself is real." But because nothing abstract is real except mathematics, because love is made of the particular and the specific , to love anything — a person, a planet, your life — is at bottom a practice of noticing, which is always a devotional practice.

In The Comfort of Crows: A Backyard Year (public library), Margaret Renkl chronicles her own reverence of reality across the seasons through the small acts of attention to wind and wren, to hemlock and hawk, which together reveal the grandeur of life. Partway between Henry Beston's The Outermost House and Robin Wall Kimmerer's Gathering Moss , what emerges is an invitation to override the mindless inertia that gets us through our days and pause to notice the details as a kind of mindfulness practice that magnifies the world.

She opens with a guided reverie under the tenderly commanding heading "Wherever You Are, Stop What You're Doing":

Stop and look at the tangled rootlets of the poison ivy vine climbing the locust tree. Notice the way they twist around each other like plaits in a golden braid, like tendrils of seaweed washed to shore...

Stop and ponder the skeleton of the snakeroot plant, each twig covered in tiny brown stars. The white petals, once embraced by bees, have dried to powder and now dust the forest floor, but here are the star-shaped sepals that held those fluffs of botanical celebration...

Stop and listen to the ragged-edged beech leaves, pale specters of the winter forest. They are chattering ghosts, clattering amid the bare branches of the other hardwoods. Wan light pours through their evanescence and burnishes them to gleaming. Deep in the gray, sleeping forest, whole beech trees flare up into whispering creatures made of trembling gold.

Stop and consider the deep hollows of the persimmon's bark, the way the tree has carved its own skin into neat rectangles of sturdy protection. See how the lacy lichens have found purchase in the channels, sharing space in the hollows...

Stop and peer at the hummingbird nest, smaller than your thumb, in the crook of the farthest reach of an oak branch. Remember the whir of hummingbird wings. Remember the green flash of hummingbird light.

Hummingbird divination from An Almanac of Birds: 100 Divinations for Uncertain Days , also available as a standalone print and as stationery cards .

In a sentiment evocative of Ursula K. Le Guin's spare and haunting poem "Kinship," Renkl adds:

Stop and think for a time about kinship. Think for a long time about kinship. The world lies before you, a lavish garden. However hobbled by waste, however fouled by graft and tainted by deception, it will always take your breath away. We were never cast out of Eden. We merely turned from it and shut our eyes. To return and be welcomed, cleansed and redeemed, we are only obliged to look.

It may be that pausing to look is indeed our moral obligation to the universe — the ultimate affirmation of being alive, repaying our debt of gratitude for the supremely statistically improbable miracle of having been born at all, which makes the practice of noticing our mightiest antidote to the fear of death.

For Renkl, this suddenly becomes more than a philosophical disposition — in the final weeks of her yearlong chronicle, as autumn is lulling the living world into a state of suspended animation, a routine medical screening fissures the denial of death by which we survive our lives. When the biopsy comes back negative, Renkl readily recognizes that "such news is only ever a reprieve." She writes:

Maybe it was the sudden sense of death dislodged, however temporarily, that made me look at the small, seasonal deaths around me with a feeling of kinship. Fallen leaves soften the path I walk on, but not for my sake. The leaves fall to feed the trees, to shelter the creatures who are essential to this forest in a way that I will never be. The misty rain unstiffens deadwood, making places for nesting woodpeckers to excavate next spring. I can stop to count the rings of shelf fungi on a dead tree and know how long they have been growing, how long the death of the tree has been feeding the life of the forest.

So much life springs from all this death that to spend time in the woods is also to contemplate immortality. On the way

The Invention of Zero: How Ancient Mesopotamia Created the Mathematical Concept of Nought and Ancient India Gave It Symbolic Form

Maria Popova · The Marginalian (Brain Pickings)

“If you look at zero you see nothing; but look through it and you will see the world.”

If the ancient Arab world had closed its gates to foreign travelers, we would have no medicine, no astronomy, and no mathematics — at least not as we know them today.

Central to humanity’s quest to grasp the nature of the universe and make sense of our own existence is zero, which began in Mesopotamia and spurred one of the most significant paradigm shifts in human consciousness — a concept first invented (or perhaps discovered) in pre-Arab Sumer, modern-day Iraq, and later given symbolic form in ancient India. This twining of meaning and symbol not only shaped mathematics, which underlies our best models of reality, but became woven into the very fabric of human life, from the works of Shakespeare, who famously winked at zero in King Lear by calling it “an O without a figure,” to the invention of the bit that gave us the 1s and 0s underpinning my ability to type these words and your ability to read them on this screen.

Mathematician Robert Kaplan chronicles nought’s revolutionary journey in The Nothing That Is: A Natural History of Zero (public library). It is, in a sense, an archetypal story of scientific discovery, wherein an abstract concept derived from the observed laws of nature is named and given symbolic form. But it is also a kind of cross-cultural fairy tale that romances reason across time and space

Kaplan writes:

If you look at zero you see nothing; but look through it and you will see the world. For zero brings into focus the great, organic sprawl of mathematics, and mathematics in turn the complex nature of things. From counting to calculating, from estimating the odds to knowing exactly when the tides in our affairs will crest, the shining tools of mathematics let us follow the tacking course everything takes through everything else – and all of their parts swing on the smallest of pivots, zero

With these mental devices we make visible the hidden laws controlling the objects around us in their cycles and swerves. Even the mind itself is mirrored in mathematics, its endless reflections now confusing, now clarifying insight.

[...]

As we follow the meanderings of zero’s symbols and meanings we’ll see along with it the making and doing of mathematics — by humans, for humans. No god gave it to us. Its muse speaks only to those who ardently pursue her.

With an eye to the eternal question of whether mathematics is discovered or invented — a question famously debated by Kurt Gödel and the Vienna Circle — Kaplan observes:

The disquieting question of whether zero is out there or a fiction will call up the perennial puzzle of whether we invent or discover the way of things, hence the yet deeper issue of where we are in the hierarchy. Are we creatures or creators, less than – or only a little less than — the angels in our power to appraise?

Like all transformative inventions, zero began with necessity — the necessity for counting without getting bemired in the inelegance of increasingly large numbers. Kaplan writes:

Zero began its career as two wedges pressed into a wet lump of clay, in the days when a superb piece of mental engineering gave us the art of counting.

[...]

The story begins some 5,000 years ago with the Sumerians, those lively people who settled in Mesopotamia (part of what is now Iraq). When you read, on one of their clay tablets, this exchange between father and son: “Where did you go?” “Nowhere.” “Then why are you late?”, you realize that 5,000 years are like an evening gone.

The Sumerians counted by 1s and 10s but also by 60s. This may seem bizarre until you recall that we do too, using 60 for minutes in an hour (and 6 × 60 = 360 for degrees in a circle). Worse, we also count by 12 when it comes to months in a year, 7 for days in a week, 24 for hours in a day and 16 for ounces in a pound or a pint. Up until 1971 the British counted their pennies in heaps of 12 to a shilling but heaps of 20 shillings to a pound.

Tug on each of these different systems and you’ll unravel a history of customs and compromises, showing what you thought was quirky to be the most natural thing in the world. In the case of the Sumerians, a 60-base (sexagesimal) system most likely sprang from their dealings with another culture whose system of weights — and hence of monetary value — differed from their own.

Having to reconcile the decimal and sexagesimal counting systems was a source of growing confusion for the Sumerians, who wrote by pressing the tip of a hollow reed to create circles and semi-circles onto wet clay tablets solidified by baking. The reed eventually became a three-sided stylus, which made triangular cuneiform marks at varying angles to designate different numbers, amounts, and concepts. Kaplan demonstrates what the Sumerian numerical system looked like by 2000 BCE:

This cumbersome system lasted for thousands of years, until someone at some point between the sixth and third centuries BCE came up with a way to wedge accounting columns apart, effectively symbolizing “nothing in this col-

Mailbag #2

Tim Urban · Wait But Why

Last month, I emailed readers announcing an upcoming mailbag post—the WBW post version of an AMA. 1,500 questions poured in—remarkably interesting, creative questions on a wide range of topics. I picked some for this round, and we're keeping the rest in a database that I'll go back to for future mailbags (mailbag@waitbutwhy.com is always open, so send questions anytime and we'll add them to the list).

There's a lot to cover, so let's get going.

Question from my 7-year-old: How many germs would you have to put together to actually be able to see them? What would it look like? – Kirsten, Zachary's mum (Sydney, Australia)

You're my kind of guy, Zachary. Let's discuss.

There are a lot of germs out there. A smaller germ, like the virus that causes covid, is 120nm across. The smallest object we can see is about 0.1mm—about the width of a human hair. You'd have to line up about 800 coronaviruses to get to 0.1mm—but that would be a one-dimensional line way too thin to see. To actually see something, you'd have to give it some area and turn the 800-virus line into an 800 x 800 square. That clump of 640,000 viruses would be just big enough to see as a tiny speck. [1] As for what it would look like, your guess is as good as mine Zachary.

I'm never good at stopping once I start on an exploration of size, and doing this answer got me googling all kinds of things.

Like how big all the bacteria in the human body would be if you clumped it all together. I had always heard the famous stat that there are 10 times as many bacteria in your body as human cells. It turns out that that's been debunked . The real ratio is closer to 1:1, with both kinds of cells in the ballpark of 40 trillion in an adult human body. [2]

Anyway, the NIH estimates that all that bacteria adds up to only 0.3% of a human's body mass. Zachary is 7, so let's estimate his mass at 25 kg. That means the bacteria in his body adds up to 75 grams—about the weight of a plum. Assuming the density of Zachary's bacteria is similar to the density of his body, that would make the bacteria ball about the size of a plum too.

This led me to the obvious next question: how big would all the bacteria on Earth be if you bunched them all together? [3]

Thankfully, University of Georgia microbiologist William Whitman has done the hard work of coming up with an estimate for the number of bacteria on Earth: 5 nonillion.

That's 5,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000.

To couple that estimate with a wild estimate of our own, we can use the volume of an E. coli bacteria ($.7\mu m^3$) and assume that's somewhere around the average size of Earth bacteria. 5 nonillion x $.7\mu m^3$ comes out to a cube with a base of about 15km (9.5mi).

This massive cube of bacteria covers a large part of Los Angeles and rises higher than the cruising altitude of commercial airplanes. If you were on the ground, it would take a full day to walk around the cube, and it would be a bad experience because the whole day you'd be right next to a vile bacteria cube.

If we took a huge butter knife and smeared the cube out evenly on the Earth's surface, it would cover the entire Earth with a layer of pure bacteria 7mm (1/4 inch) thick, and everything would be gross.

K let's move on.

What do you think of scientists putting mini human brains in mice? Where do you think this kind of science could lead in the future? – Leah N. (Quincy, IL)

I have no idea what's going on with this question but it's now all I care about. I'm picturing a world with tiny field mice with human intelligence. They'd form tiny societies run by tiny iron-fisted mouse tyrants. They could have little academies and do research on mice-related things. They might organize a mouse Olympics that we could televise and bet on. Some people would befriend mice and some might even choose to get married to mice. I hope this is what you're talking about Leah, and I refuse to look it up because I'm sure whatever you're actually talking about will be a huge letdown.

Drugs: do you do them? What do you think of them? – Tom C. (Nottingham, UK)

Kind of what I think of cars. Cars can be incredibly useful, fun, and life-changing if you understand how cars work and know how to drive safely. If you don't know anything about driving or you tend to drive recklessly, you're probably not ready to use cars.

Why do we prefer to watch a film we haven't watched before but we want to listen to songs that we have heard hundreds of times? – Anastasia S. (Athens, Greece)

Many films are the most fun the first time because a part of our brains loses itself in the plot and actually experiences what the characters are experiencing, to an extent. Part of why that's so fun is the uncertainty, which makes it like a real-life adventure. Once we know what's going to happen, the experience is less exciting for the same reason an adventure would be less exciting if you already knew how everything was gonna play out.

A song works the opposite way. Not knowing where the song is going can be intellectually interesting, but what our brain really wants to do is mentally dance with the song, and it can't do that if it doesn't know the "steps." That's why a catchy song is only okay the first time but it can quickly

Ancient Scroll Reveals Lost Miracle Of Christ Correctly Guessing People’s Weights

The Onion Staff · The Onion

JERUSALEM—Historians confirmed Friday that a recent archaeological find in the Judean Hills is an authentic early Christian scroll, one that depicts the previously unknown miracle of Jesus Christ correctly guessing people’s weights just by looking at them. “The papyrus is remarkably well-preserved, with an unbroken Aramaic script that describes Christ strolling through Galilee with a serene smile, calling out, ‘Come forth, all ye people, but for a single coin of silver,’ before closing His eyes and naming a weight that was always accurate within a few shekels,” said biblical scholar Harris Solomon, noting that the scroll depicts a clay jar of small prizes kept beside Christ at all times to be handed out to anyone whose weight He guessed wrong, something that, according to the text, never occurred. “This scroll completely upends our traditional image of Jesus, as the text describes Him not in simple robes and a beard but in a pinstripe tunic with a waxed mustache. Yet Christ’s generosity is still evident, as one passage recounts Him performing His miracle for an emaciated leper free of charge. The verse reads, ‘And lo, He lifted His hand and spake: The leper’s weight is one talent, 19 minas, and 13 shekels. And they were sore amazed, for it was true unto the very last measure.’” The newly unearthed scroll also reveals that in quieter moments, Christ would cover Himself in silver dust and stand motionless on a box on the side of a busy Nazareth street, miraculously transforming Himself into a statue for hours on end.

The post Ancient Scroll Reveals Lost Miracle Of Christ Correctly Guessing People’s Weights appeared first on The Onion .

ANALYSIS

Tom Breihan, Stereogum: Veteran singer-songwriter Ashley Monroe has had a long, checkered run in the Nashville country music business. She's had a lot of success, partly as one third of Miranda Lambert's great side project Pistol Annies, but she's also bounced around from label to label, making her own deep and heartfelt music while singing backup on records...

The post Ashley Monroe Releases Surprise New Concept Album Dear Nashville appeared first on Stereogum .

Chris DeVille, Stereogum: Like many bands of yesteryear, the Scottish rockers Big Country, makers of the 1983 hit "In A Big Country," have splintered into various units on the touring circuit over the years. Also like many of those bands, they're now fighting about who gets to use the band name.

The post Big Country Drummer Must Stop Touring As Big Country, Say Rest Of Big Country appeared first on Stereogum .

Danielle Chelosky, Stereogum: Last year, Dua Lipa was busy touring 2024's Radical Optimism and bringing out guests like Charli XCX and Ben Gibbard in addition to performing covers like Sinead O'Connor's " Nothing Compares 2 U " and Daft Punk's " Get Lucky ." Now, the British singer is getting ready to focus on acting again, as she's joined the cast for Molly Gordon's new movie Peaked .

The post Dua Lipa Joins Connor Storrie In Molly Gordon's New Movie Peaked appeared first on Stereogum .

Kieran Fisher, /Film: Everyone has a favorite Western film, but we're highlighting five you might have missed from the 1960s that still hold up today.

Andy Swift, TVLine: Virgin River has yet to reveal the name of Mel and Jack's new baby, but after speaking with Alexandra Breckenridge, TVLine has a pretty good idea what it'll be.

Rafael Motamayor, /Film: Rebecca Ferguson is the star of Apple TV's sci-fi show Silo, but her involvement as an executive producer means her love runs even deeper.

Bill Bria, /Film: Millie Bobby Brown's costume for the final season of Stranger Things was inspired by the Goonies, but she wasn't excited about wearing it.

Craig Blair, Canon Rumors: We all know about the current market conditions for various storage solutions. The AI datacenter demand that won't subside for years has already taken Micron out of the consumer market, and now Sony is suspending sales of their CFexpress Type A, Type B and SDXC/SDHC memory cards. Statement from Sony (Translated) Due to the global […]

Margaret Farrell, Stereogum: Sometimes a house is more than just a structure. It is a place that holds our desires and taste and the things that we love. It's both physical space and a dream. Empress Of returns with a silky new single that captures such a building's many layers. It's a synth-pop balm where Lorely Rodriguez' vocals...

The post Empress Of – "Dream House" appeared first on Stereogum .

Andy Swift, TVLine: After lending her voice to Family Guy for 14 seasons, Alexandra Breckenridge was finally animated into an episode as Virgin River's Mel - and she had no idea.

Debopriyaa Dutta, /Film: The Guyver, featuring Mark Hamill, evokes a slightly grown-up version of Power Rangers, which is enjoyable in itself if you completely ignore its manga roots.

Jillg366, Deadline Hollywood: Bollywood hit Dhurandhar: The Revenge from Moviegoers. Entertainment is no. 4 in its second weekend on 987 screens with a gross of $4.9 million and a cume of $22.9 million. Aditya Dhar directs Ranveer Singh as an undercover agent in Pakistan in a rare Indian film to keep a top ranking for a second weekend. […]

PHD Comics, PHD Comics: Piled Higher & Deeper by Jorge Cham

www.phdcomics.com

title: " NEW BOOK! Out of Your Mind! " - originally published 1/15/2021

For the latest news in PHD Comics, CLICK HERE!

Devin Meenan, /Film: Two of the darkest episodes of Battlestar Galactica were clearly influenced by another sci-fi story's all timer of an ending.

Tom Breihan, Stereogum: The veteran rapper/producer Oddisee has been making beautiful music for a very long time now. Last year, he released an EP called En Route. Next month, he'll team up with Heno., a relatively new rapper from Takoma Park, Maryland, to release a new album called From Takoma With Love. Oddisee is based in Brooklyn these...

The post Oddisee & Heno. Announce New Album From Takoma With Love : Hear "MIMS" appeared first on Stereogum .

Tom Breihan, Stereogum: For the past few years, rap great Danny Brown has been collaborating heavily with underground hyperpop producers. He loves that stuff! Those collaborations built up to the release of Stardust, the album that Brown released last year, but they didn't end there. Now, Brown's got a new collaboration with an artist who I'd never heard...

The post girl_irl & Danny Brown – "Magic" appeared first on Stereogum .

Kieran Fisher, /Film: 'I'm sure none of it was legal,' Renée Zellweger said regarding her time filming Texas Chainsaw Massacre: The Next Generation.

Matthew Carey, Deadline Hollywood: "Watch what you eat" used to be a commonly heard expression, typically urged in the context of dieting. But the maxim applies in a different way in the documentary Fork in the Road, which made its world premiere Saturday at the Sonoma International Film Festival in California's wine country. The film directed by Vivian Sorenson […]

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